

The empirical recurrence for OEIS A233021, proved by transfer matrix

Adrian Perez Fontelles

Independent researcher

3 September 2026

Abstract

OEIS A233021 counts arrays over $\{0, \dots, 3\}$ in which no two entries that are neighbours in a named set of directions may sum to 3, together with clauses that pick one array out of each class of arrays differing by a renaming. The entry carries an empirical recurrence of order 4 contributed by R. H. Hardin. It is true, and it is decidable rather than empirical: the clash condition is local to two consecutive rows and the renaming clauses are carried by one bounded piece of extra state, so the count is a walk count on $S = 36$ states.

2020 Mathematics Subject Classification. 05A15, 05C15, 15A18.

1 The conjecture

OEIS A233021 is “Number of $n \times 3$ 0..3 arrays with no element $x(i,j)$ adjacent to value $3-x(i,j)$ horizontally, vertically, diagonally or antidiagonally, and top left element zero.”. It has offset 1 and begins

$$9, 81, 849, 8835, 92067, 959385, 9997413, 104179551, \dots$$

The entry states, as a conjecture contributed by its author and never marked settled:

$$\text{Empirical: } a(n) = 11*a(n-1) - 5*a(n-2) - 11*a(n-3) + 2*a(n-4).$$

As of the “Last modified” line on the live entry (Oct 07 2018 08:36:50, revision 8) this is still recorded as empirical, and nothing on the entry records it as proved.

2 What is being counted

The array is 3 cells across with entries $x(i,j) \in \{0, 1, 2, 3\}$. Call two values u, v CLASHING when $u + v = 3$. Two cells are neighbours when one is obtained from the other by one of the offsets

$$(0, 1), (1, -1), (1, 0), (1, 1),$$

that is, in the horizontal, antidiagonal (ne–sw), vertical and diagonal (nw–se) directions, and the condition is that no two neighbouring cells carry clashing values. The clash relation is symmetric, so an offset and its negative name the same pairs and only one of each is listed. The entry also fixes the top left entry: $x(1, 1) = 0$.

3 The walk

Every offset above moves the row index by at most one, so a clash is a condition on two consecutive array rows and on nothing else.

So a single array row is a state. A step appends a row, which settles every clash between it and the row above and every clash inside it. There are $S = 36$ reachable states.

With ι the indicator of the states that may begin an array and $\tau = \mathbf{1}$,

$$a(n) = \iota^\top M^j \tau.$$

The walk index j and the entry's own n differ by a constant, read off by matching the published terms rather than assumed. In particular a is C -finite.

4 The proof

Lemma 1. *Let $q(t) = t^4 - \sum_i c_i t^{4-i}$ be the characteristic polynomial of the conjectured recurrence. The residual $a(n) - \sum_i c_i a(n-i)$ equals $\iota^\top M^j q(M) \tau$ for the corresponding walk index j , so the recurrence holds from some point on if and only if $\iota^\top M^j q(M) \tau = 0$ for all large j , and it is enough to examine $j < S$.*

Proof. Factor M^j out of $M^{j+4} - \sum_i c_i M^{j+4-i}$. For the bound, M^S is an integer combination of $I, M, \dots, M^{S-1}$ by Cayley–Hamilton, so the numbers $u_j = \iota^\top M^j q(M) \tau$ obey the monic recurrence given by the characteristic polynomial of M ; S consecutive zeros force every later one, and the last nonzero u_j pins the threshold exactly. $\square$

Theorem 2.

$$a(n) = 11a(n-1) - 5a(n-2) - 11a(n-3) + 2a(n-4)$$

for every $n > 4$.

Proof. The vector $w = q(M)\tau$ was formed by 4 matrix–vector products in exact integer arithmetic and $\iota^\top M^j w$ evaluated for $j = 0, 1, \dots$, again exactly; those integers vanish from the index corresponding to $n = 4 + 1$ onwards and the run continued until the working vector was identically zero, which settles every larger j at once. $\square$

5 Verification

Four checks, each independent of the algebra above.

First, the model reproduces all 17 terms the entry publishes, exactly, in integer arithmetic.

Second, the count was recomputed for the smallest arrays straight from the definition: fill the cells in row major order, in the orientation the entry's own name writes, and test each clause the moment it can be tested. No transfer matrix, no transposition and no state are involved, and the published terms came back.

Third, the conjectured recurrence was evaluated directly on the published terms, with no matrices involved, and holds wherever the proved range and the data overlap.

Fourth, the annihilation test of Lemma 1 was carried out in exact integer arithmetic on the whole vector rather than on a sampled prefix.

References

- [1] The OEIS Foundation, *The On-Line Encyclopedia of Integer Sequences*, <https://oeis.org>, 2026. Sequence A233021.

- [2] R. P. Stanley, *Enumerative Combinatorics*, Volume 1, 2nd ed., Cambridge University Press, 2011. (Transfer-matrix method, Section 4.7.)
- [3] J. E. Hopcroft, R. Motwani and J. D. Ullman, *Introduction to Automata Theory, Languages, and Computation*, 3rd ed., Addison–Wesley, 2006.
- [4] R. A. Horn and C. R. Johnson, *Matrix Analysis*, 2nd ed., Cambridge University Press, 2013.